

Writing Your Project, Section by Section

ECON 692 – Applied Economics Seminar

Andrew Hobbs

University of San Francisco

April 9, 2026

Today's Agenda

Time	Duration	Activity
4:35	10 min	Check-in: where are you on the draft?
4:45	30 min	Writing section by section: intro through conclusion
5:15	10 min	Break
5:25	20 min	Good vs. bad examples
5:45	25 min	GitHub Pages: project sites & blogs
6:10	80 min	Work sprint
7:30	25 min	Peer feedback
7:55	20 min	Wrap-up & next steps

Check-in

Quick poll:

- Who has a complete results section?
- Who has started writing prose (intro, empirical strategy, anything)?
- Who is doing a blog or website instead of a traditional write-up?

Full Draft is due April 24 — two weeks from today.

That means a complete project — paper, blog series, or site — with intro, empirical strategy, results, and conclusion. Today: how to write each section.

The Introduction Formula

The Introduction Formula

Whether it's a paper or a blog post, the intro follows the same structure:

1. **Motivation** — a fact, cost, or puzzle that creates stakes
2. **Research question** — “I estimate...” or “This project examines...”
3. **Contribution** — what's new, positioned against prior work
4. **Method** — your identification strategy, in one paragraph
5. **Findings** — main results with actual numbers/directions
6. **Roadmap** — section outline (keep it short)

Based on Evans (CGDev), Head (UBC), and Sahm (MacroMom). Links on course site.

The First Three Paragraphs

1. Motivation

- It *matters* — people are helped or hurt
- It's *puzzling* — defies easy explanation
- It's *controversial* — economists disagree
- It's *big* or widespread

Be specific: a number, a policy, a cost.

2. Research Question

- By end of ¶2: “I estimate...” or “This project examines...”
- After citing others, use “I” or “my analysis” — “this” is ambiguous

3. Contribution

- Aim for ~3 contributions
- Most important first
- New economic knowledge > new method/data
- Frame each against specific prior work

The test: if a reader stops after ¶3, do they know (1) why the topic matters, (2) what you did, and (3) why it's new?

Method, Findings, Roadmap

4. Method (1 paragraph)

- Summarize your identification strategy
- Name the design: DiD, IV, RDD, etc.
- Save details for the empirical strategy section

5. Findings (1–2 paragraphs)

- One sentence per main result — with direction and magnitude
- “I find that a 10% increase in X reduces Y by 3%”
- Don’t make the reader wait 20 pages to find out what you found

6. Roadmap (short)

- One sentence per section
- Be specific to *your* project
- Not: “The next section reviews the literature”
- Better: “Section 2 documents trends in rural hospital closures since 2010”

Total length: 1.5–2 pages for a capstone, 3–5 paragraphs for a blog post. The intro is an executive summary — it should stand alone.

Lead with Your Work

Every element of the intro should open with *your* contribution, then position it in the literature.

Don't:

“Smith (2010) found X. Jones (2012) extended this to Y. Lee (2015) showed Z. Building on this literature, I also examine...”

Three sentences about other people before the reader finds out what *you* did.

Do:

“I provide the first causal estimates of X using staggered policy variation. While Smith (2010) and Jones (2012) documented correlations, my design exploits...”

Your contribution is the first thing the reader sees.
Literature supports it.

This applies to every paragraph: contribution, method, findings. Lead with yours, then cite. And don't trash prior work — tell us what *your* analysis adds.

Common Intro Mistakes

- **Too broad.** “Since the beginning of time, economies have...” Start with your specific topic.
- **Bait and switch.** The hook promises something interesting, but the analysis delivers something narrower and less compelling.
- **“All my friends are doing it.”** Motivating your project because others wrote on the topic, not because the question itself matters.
- **Burying the contribution.** If your reader gets to page 3 without knowing what you did, you’ve lost them.
- **No results preview.** The intro should tell the reader what you *found*. An intro without findings is a promissory note.
- **Mixing intro and lit review.** Cite a few key papers to position your work. Save the deep engagement for the body.

Optional Sections

Do You Need a Background Section?

Some papers include a standalone section between the intro and empirical strategy. You don't have to — but here's when it helps:

- **Institutional detail.** Your setting needs explanation that doesn't fit in the intro — how a policy works, a timeline of changes, features of a market.
- **Literature review.** The intro cites a few key papers. A lit review goes deeper — grouping by theme, synthesizing findings, identifying gaps.
- **Theory / conceptual framework.** A model or predictions that motivate your empirical tests. Common in IO and trade, less so in applied micro.

If you include one, it has one job: make the reader understand *why your empirical strategy makes sense*. Otherwise, fold the key points into your intro.

Writing the Data Section

The Data Section

The data section answers: **what are you working with, and should I trust it?**

1. **Source.** Where does the data come from? How was it collected?
2. **Unit of observation.** What is a row? Person-year? County-month? Firm?
3. **Sample.** Time period, geographic scope, sample size. What's excluded and why?
4. **Key variables.** How are treatment, outcome, and controls measured? Be precise — “income” could mean ten different things.
5. **Summary statistics.** A table of means, SDs, and counts. Separate by treatment/control if relevant.

A reader who skips straight to your results table should be able to come back here and understand every column.

Anatomy of the Empirical Strategy

The Empirical Strategy Recipe

This section should convince a skeptic that your approach is sound.

Four ingredients, in order:

1. **Data.** Unit of observation, time period, sample size, key variables. Where does it come from? What's excluded and why?
2. **Identification.** What variation are you exploiting? Why is it plausibly exogenous? What's the identifying assumption?
3. **Estimation.** The model. Write down the equation. Explain every term.
4. **Inference.** How are standard errors clustered? Why that level?

If you don't have an equation in this section, something is missing.

The Identification Argument

The identification argument is the heart of your empirical strategy. It answers: **why should I believe this is causal?**

For DiD:

- What's the treatment? When did it happen?
- Who's treated vs. control?
- Why is parallel trends plausible?
- What threatens it?

For IV:

- What's the instrument?
- Why is it relevant? (first stage)
- Why is it excludable?
- What would violate exclusion?

For every method: state the assumption, argue for it, and acknowledge what could go wrong.

Common Empirical Strategy Mistakes

- **No equation.** “I run a regression of Y on X with controls” isn’t enough. Write it out:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta D_{it} + X'_{it}\gamma + \mu_i + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{it}$$

- **Skipping the “why this works” argument.** Don’t just describe what you do. Explain *why* it gives you a credible estimate.
- **Mixing in results.** This section is about *design*, not findings. Save the coefficients for the results section.
- **No discussion of threats.** Every strategy has weaknesses. Name them. The reader will think of them anyway — better if you get there first.

Results, Discussion, Conclusion

The Results Section

We covered this in detail last week. The short version:

1. **Lead with your main result.** State the finding in plain English before the reader hits the table.
2. **Walk through the table.** Point to the key coefficient, its magnitude, and its significance. Don't just say "see Table 2."
3. **Build from simple to complex.** Start with the baseline specification, then add controls, fixed effects, robustness checks.
4. **Interpret economically, not just statistically.** "A 10% increase in X reduces Y by 3 percentage points" is more useful than " $p < 0.01$."

Every table and figure should be referenced in the text. If you don't discuss it, cut it.

Discussion and Limitations

This is where you step back and honestly assess what your results mean — and what they don't.

Discussion

- What do the results imply for policy or theory?
- Do they match or contradict prior work? Why?
- What's the mechanism? Can you say?

Limitations

- What threats to identification remain?
- What can't your data measure?
- How does sample selection affect generalizability?

Be honest but not self-defeating. Name the limitations, explain what you did to address them, and note what future work could do. Don't undermine your own results — just show you've thought it through.

The Conclusion

The conclusion is short — half a page to a page. Three things:

1. **Restate the question and answer.** One sentence each. The reader who skipped to the end should get the punchline.
2. **So what?** Why does this matter? Policy implications, theoretical implications, or both.
3. **What's next?** One or two sentences on future work — what would make this analysis stronger or extend it in an interesting direction?

Don't introduce new results or new arguments. Don't repeat the abstract. Don't end with “more research is needed” — be specific about *what* research and *why*.

Good vs. Bad Examples

Intro: Weak vs. Strong

Weak:

“Minimum wages have been debated for a long time. Many economists have studied this topic. Some find positive effects and some find negative effects. I look at minimum wages and employment.”

Problems: no hook, no stakes, no specific question, vague contribution.

Strong:

“Twenty-three states raised their minimum wage in 2024, affecting over 8 million workers. Whether these increases reduce employment remains contested. I exploit the staggered timing of state-level increases to estimate the effect on teen employment using a stacked DiD design.”

Hook (fact), stakes (scale), question (implicit), method (clear).

Empirical Strategy: Weak vs. Strong

Weak:

“I use difference-in-differences. The treatment group is states that raised the minimum wage. The control group is states that didn’t. I control for GDP and population.”

No equation, no identifying assumption, no parallel trends discussion.

Strong:

“I estimate $Y_{st} = \beta D_{st} + X'_{st}\gamma + \mu_s + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{st}$, where D_{st} indicates state s raised its minimum wage by period t . Identification requires parallel employment trends absent the policy. I provide evidence in Section 5.”

Equation, named assumption, roadmap to evidence.

GitHub Pages

Blog Series: The First Post Matters Most

If you're writing a blog series, your first post is your intro — and it needs to be a full executive summary, not just “I'm going to study X.”

A first post that doesn't tell the reader what you found won't get them to post two. Include:

- Why this question matters (the hook)
- What you did and what you found (the punchline)
- What's coming in the rest of the series (the roadmap)

The remaining sections — data, empirical strategy, results, discussion — each become their own post. Same content, more conversational tone.

Let's talk about how to set that up with GitHub Pages.

What Is GitHub Pages?

Free static website hosting, straight from a GitHub repo.

- Your repo already has code and data. GitHub Pages lets you add a website on top of it.
- URL: `yourusername.github.io/your-repo/`
- Supports HTML, Markdown, and — most usefully — Quarto.
- No server to manage. Push your files, the site updates.

Two Options

1. **Simple:** Write Markdown files, enable Pages, done.
2. **Polished:** Use Quarto to build a blog or multi-page site.

Option 1: Simple Markdown Site

If you just want a single-page write-up:

1. Create docs/index.md in your repo
2. Write your content in Markdown
3. **Settings** → **Pages** → source: main branch, /docs folder
4. Push. Your site is live.

```
your-repo/  
  docs/  
    index.md      # your write-up  
    figures/      # images for the site  
  code/  
    analysis.R
```

GitHub renders the Markdown as HTML automatically. No build step needed.

Option 2: Quarto Blog

For multiple posts, a polished layout, or interactive figures:

```
# Create a blog project
quarto create project blog my-capstone-blog

# Structure:
my-capstone-blog/
  _quarto.yml           # site config
  index.qmd             # landing page
  posts/
    01-question/
      index.qmd         # "Why I'm studying this"
    02-data/
      index.qmd         # "The data"
    03-results/
      index.qmd         # "What I found"
```

Run `quarto render` to build, then push the output to GitHub Pages.

Setting Up GitHub Pages

1. Go to your repo on GitHub
2. **Settings** → **Pages** (left sidebar)
3. Source: **Deploy from a branch**, branch: `main`, folder: `/docs`
4. Click **Save**

For Quarto: set the output directory in `_quarto.yml`:

```
project:  
  type: website  
  output-dir: docs
```

Then `quarto render && git add docs/ && git push`. Site updates in about a minute.

Work Sprint

Work Sprint (6:05–7:30)

Pick your track:

Write-up Track

1. Write your intro (at least 2 paragraphs)
2. Write your empirical strategy section (at least 1 page)
3. If time: add institutional detail or context

Website/Blog Track

1. Set up GitHub Pages on your repo
2. Create your first page or post
3. Write the “question and why it matters” section

I'll come around for check-ins. If you're stuck on how to start, try this: write the one-sentence version of your contribution, then expand outward.

Peer Feedback & Wrap-up

Peer Feedback (7:30–7:55)

Swap your intro (or first blog post) with a neighbor.

5 minutes: Read silently. Then answer:

1. Can you state their research question in one sentence?
2. Is the contribution clear — do you know what they did and what they found?
3. Where did you get confused or lose the thread?

If you can't answer #1 after reading the intro, that's the most useful feedback you can give.

Next Week & Deadlines

Next week (4/16): Figures, tables, slide design, and presentation prep.

Upcoming:

- Weekly progress report due **Wednesday**
- **Full Draft due April 24** (two weeks)

Between Now and the Full Draft

You need a complete project: intro, empirical strategy, results, conclusion. Leave today with a drafted intro and empirical strategy, and you're in good shape.